



Not football, but Mexico finds joy in another World Cup

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In life, if one door closes, another, more often than not, creaks open.

In the last few months, only one World Cup had made rounds in headlines, that of football, happening in the United States of America, Canada and Mexico.

Though title hopes for all three fizzled out by the round of 32, Mexico found ways to celebrate in another World Cup — one played beneath RGB lights, inside an indoor arena, with loud music and LED displays: the Esports World Cup.

Mexican gamer Luis Guadalupe Castillo Gomez, known as 'DarkAngel' (in picture), became the first champion in the 2026 Esports World Cup, winning the FATAL FURY: City of the Wolves title in Paris, France.

In a tournament where last year's finalists failed to make it to the last eight, DarkAngel, a Terry Bogard specialist, outplayed Reynald Tacsuan and Naoki "Nemo" Nemoto before getting the better of Kenta "mi2ha4" Ichihara in the grand finale.

After settling for bronze last year, the 29-year-old went two steps further this time, winning the summit clash 5-1 and taking home \$250,000 in prize money and a confirmed spot at the SNK World Championship 2026 Finals for Fatal Fury, which will also feature a \$ 2,500,000 prize pool.

The Worlds will take place in Stockholm from November 27 to 29.

Back in India, however, there was disappointment for Vidit Gujrathi, who was eyeing a spot in the same

tournament, albeit in chess. Competing in the India Rising qualifier in Mumbai, he lost 1-2 to Dutch Grandmaster Benjamin Bok.

But the country with a reigning Chess World Champion (D. Gukesh) and with a double in the Chess Olympiad 2025 will still have a substantial presence at the Esports World Cup.

Nihal Sarin (S8UL), Arvindh Chidambaram (S8UL) and Arjun Erigaisi (Gen. G Esports) across two clubs, will look to make the tricolour proud, though they will compete as part of clubs, in Paris between August 11 and 16.

Esports has floated into mainstream sports conversations in India more often than ever. And the country now has communities looking to ensure a brighter future, along with the present.

An attempt for that very goal saw KRAFTON — the South Korean firm behind the game PUBG — host the inaugural KRAFTON India Rising Star Invitational 2026 in early July, wherein Team Krazy Kratos emerged the champion.

The tournament is another step for the Rising Star program from KRAFTON, which aims at grooming young athletes for competitive gaming.

Kratos secured the title with 193 points and three Winner Winner Chicken Dinners (WWCDs). Justy's Jesters finished as runner-up with 166 points, while Most Wanted claimed third place with 146 points and two WWCDs.

Rohit "KRATOS" Saxena, the in-game leader of Kratos, was named both the Most Valuable Player and Best Rising Star of the tournament.